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Lucía Gómez (A)

Santiago Álvarez de Mon

I was born in Alicante, one of five children. Apart from two years in Cadiz, I spent the first seventeen years of my life in my home town. When I was seventeen I came to Madrid to do a degree in Business Studies. I was thinking of going into Medicine, probably out of a humanitarian ambition to do something for other people. But I realised that you can also help others in business, because when it comes down to it business is all about people too.

Did you enjoy living in Madrid?

I spent six very happy years here. The first year I lived in my grandmother's house, then I moved into a students' residence. The other people in the residence become like a second family to you. You don't feel you're all alone in the big city because the others feel the same way; you form a very close-knit sort of "family". I used to visit my parents quite regularly. You learn to value your family much more when you're far away, you stop thinking of your parents as ogres, you realise they're just ordinary people who are trying to do their best for you. Living away from home helps you mature much faster.

What did you do when you graduated?

Since my English was not up to scratch I decided to go to England. I spent approximately two years there. At the beginning, for the first six months, I studied in a university called Loughborough. It was great fun, there was no pressure. After six months I decided to look for a job. They took me on at the actual university as a Spanish teacher for first-year students, and also giving classes to groups of adults. Then I started to send out applications to various companies, and I was offered a job in London, in a service company called Hospitality Group. It was a firm that organized conventions and meetings for other companies, based around sporting events such as the Rider Cup or Wimbledon, and so on. It's quite a fashion in England. It makes a good impression if you take all your executive team and arrange a kind of business meeting or working lunch in the intervals in the matches. I joined a department staffed by Spanish speakers that had been set up with the idea of exporting this type of product to Spain. I found out what it was like to be stony broke and learned to value the simple things in life, the basic necessities.

This case was prepared by Professor Santiago Álvarez de Mon. September 2019.
This case is based on the case "Carlota Fernández" from the same auhtor.
IESE cases are designed to promote class discussion rather than to illustrate effective or ineffective management of a given situation.

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Are you saying you weren't very well paid?

I was paid a pittance. But I enjoyed the experience; when it comes to the crunch, whether you like it or not, you're not going to starve. You always know you've got a safety net, you can always go back home. It was interesting, but it was nothing to boast about in terms of being bold or brave, or taking risks, because there weren't any. It's a useful experience to live in a country far away and have to learn to get by as best you can. You seize every opportunity to earn an bit of extra cash here or there, and at the same time stay on good terms with the group of friends or people who are in the same boat with you. After a year and a half I came back to Madrid with the idea of setting up a business selling advertising space in partnership with the head of Hospitality Group's Spanish section.

I stayed in that job for six months. Why did I leave? Because when you start a company with someone, you need to know that person very well. I don't think it's a good idea if it's an old friend or you have a particularly close relationship, but you do need to know the person well on a professional level. You have to know the way he works, and whether you are going to be able to work with him. You have to have a similar idea of what the business is about, you have to have faith in each other's abilities. You can't work on the basis of me keeping an eye on what you're doing and you keeping an eye on me. My partner disappointed me, and I imagine I disappointed him. It was nobody's fault, it was just that we had completely different ways of doing things. When I was 24 I decided to do the MBA program at IESE.

How did you get on at IESE in Barcelona – on an academic, human and personal level?

I found what I'd been looking for. I started to feel I knew what I wanted, and I also discovered some ideas I hadn't expected to find there. I wanted to learn so as to have an intellectual framework to build on when I left, a basic store of knowledge as a point of reference that would help me in my work. But I also discovered that you have to learn how to use the tools of management, and you have to work to develop a style of your own, and that there's more to a good manager than tools. I took all that on board and practised it with the case method and with the study groups, learning to listen, to respect others, to wait my turn to talk, not to talk out of turn. The MBA made me grow as a person, it makes you have faith in the people around you. You realise that everyone has something to say, and you mustn't ever feel superior just because you have certain qualifications or experience, or think that the other person's opinion is not worth listening to. There's always something to be gleaned. And, also, you learn to value what you yourself have to say, your own contribution.

For my summer internship I went to work for Procter & Gamble. I was working with a brand of shampoo called Wash & Go, with a person who'd also done the MBA at IESE. She was my immediate boss. I was very impressed by her intellectual capacity; I liked the way she handled the work, I liked the atmosphere, the freedom she gave you to make your own suggestions. I also have to admit that I was somewhat overawed by the sheer size of the company. There are hundreds of people, and some very senior executives; people seem to hold them in a strange mixture of fear and affection, though I personally didn't feel that way. When you're there as an intern you're at the very bottom of the ladder, so they're not going to take you to meet the global director. I felt I had an awful lot to learn.

At the end of the second year of the MBA program I started another round of job seeking. I totally discarded the idea of going into marketing. If I wanted to go into marketing, I already had Procter, so why should I go looking for another company? I started investigating the world of consulting. It seemed an interesting kind of work because you get an overall, global view of things, and you get the chance to learn about a lot of different companies. That appealed to me.

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At the same time, I felt I'd miss the hands-on part of actually executing the plans and seeing the results of what you've done. Consulting is a kind of intellectual work that really appeals to me, but there's no final product at the end of it that you can touch. I finally dropped the idea one day after an interview –one of the last I did, I don't remember who with– when someone said to me, "We're really impressed with you...", with more sweet-talk and so on, and then, "...What we *can* guarantee you is that you'll be able to sleep in your own bed at least one weekend in four." My reply to that was something along the lines of, "Thanks, but no thanks. It's been lovely meeting you. Goodbye." And that was it. I won't let anyone interfere with my private life. That's another thing I really liked about my first boss at Procter: at six o'clock she tidied all her folders away and left the office, having done a lot of quality work.

Did you only have interviews with consulting firms?

I had several. I found they come straight out and ask you... Do you have much of a family life? How do you feel about the hours? You know that you'll have to work very hard here to start with. Well, I'm not afraid of hard work, I worked very hard for the MBA, I worked very hard at Procter, and I'll always work hard wherever I am. But when it becomes a way of life I just refuse point blank. I'm not willing to accept that.

In all this time have you had any relationships that you felt could have become permanent?

I've had plenty of boyfriends, but nothing really serious or long-term, nothing that ever seemed likely to turn into a lifelong commitment –getting married, having children... nothing like that. It just hasn't materialized – yet.

What was the offer you got from Procter?

I was to be assistant brand manager, reporting directly to a brand manager. Between my job and the director there were two intermediate levels. So, as you can see, it was a very flat structure; I was very close to the core where the decisions were made. The pay was reasonable, with a bonus for the MBA.

What was it about Procter that attracted you – the fact that it was a multinational? the marketing...?

Procter is not a marketing company, it's a company where you manage a brand. And that means you're the general manager of your own little company, which might be called Max Factor, or Ariel, or Fairy. I've always liked to have a grasp of the big picture. I don't like to be a member of staff, just a small cog in a larger organization, and never get to see what the rest of the organization is doing. What's more, you're not just your own general manager, you also force yourself to specialize in subjects that have to do directly with consumers, such as advertising and communication, which are the kinds of things that have always appealed to me, because in the last analysis it boils down to talking to people, which is something I really enjoy. It also enabled me to strike a balance between my private life and my career.

As soon as I joined I saw that all the people I'd worked with weren't there any more, they'd all gone, particularly the top managers. My boss from the summer internship was still there, but the marketing manager who'd interviewed me, the people who'd given me the very first interviews at IESE, the director, they'd all gone! Oh, dear! I thought. Who's going to speak up for me now?

The advantage of spending some time in Max Factor was that it's a small brand as far as Procter is concerned. It's not as if Procter Cosmetics was one of the big leaders, and that gave me a lot of scope to do things. Together with my boss, I became the person who knew most about the

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business. That gave me a lot of confidence to make any kind of proposal to top management: they give you a free hand because they're more focused on other company brands such as Ariel or Fairy. The disadvantages were that, on the one hand, you don't have the total backing of top management, and they don't depend on you so much either. Sometimes you need them to make certain decisions, and you don't have the analytical tools they have in other brands. My budget was small, which meant I didn't have access to a lot of new tools. After a period of nine months –where the normal thing is to stay with each brand for a year and a half– they decided I should go to Ariel, Procter's flagship brand. It was around then that my mother died.

I felt I'd lost the pillar of my life. I'd always looked up to my parents. I was a great help to my mother, being the eldest girl. I was always very close to her. After a week my father, my brother and sisters and I all came to Madrid. My mother died on a Friday, and a few days later I was back at Procter. The minute I came in the door, the director called me in and said to me, "Go back home – now! Go and look after your father, and don't come back until you're feeling completely recovered." They behaved like real gentlemen, they showed me they had genuine affection for me. Not only the people I worked with on a one-to-one basis, but also people who didn't have that much to do with me. I remember one manager who said to me, "*You* are the most important thing. The organization will survive without you, and we want you back here in good form, when you feel ready."

After a month I went back to work. Ariel is a huge brand, it's tremendous. There were three of us assistant brand managers, and instead of having a brand manager we had a person who was halfway between a brand manager and the Marketing Director, who at that time was called the Marketing Manager. He was a person who had a lot of experience, one of the most highly skilled professionals I've ever met, both from the point of view of brains and from the point of view of managing his agenda. He was English; I stayed with him for two and a half years. The change was extraordinary: after having worked with a lot of freedom and very little supervision in a small brand, I was now in a giant brand, with everybody watching my every move. Even the people who came in the evening to clean the offices knew all about Ariel, everybody had an opinion. And that's exhausting, because all your decisions are very complex. Even so, during that period I tried to influence people, it was a great challenge. You find you're the last link in a chain in which you are actually the grass roots of the business; in other words, a drop in sales of Ariel means a drop in sales in Spain. It's very difficult for you to do anything at all without everyone else in the organization being in agreement. You have to learn to sell things to your middle managers, you have to learn to be on good terms with everyone so that later they'll smooth the way for you to make certain decisions. Personally, I didn't like it; you gradually start to realise, "Why do I have to do all this work across the organization? It gets me nowhere; it gives me a good name, but it doesn't help me sell more, or do things faster, or be more efficient." A certain amount of office politics is probably necessary in any organization, there are a lot of people higher up who have influence at a European level – but I found it rather exhausting... I didn't like it, but I think all the same it's interesting to know what it's like. It becomes the world you live in.

How does a typical matrix structure work? Don't you get contradictory instructions – neither black nor white, but grey?

Procter operated according to what was known as brand management. I was an assistant brand manager, I worked on my brand, and I was a specialist in communication and everything to do with consumers. But built around that there are a lot of staff departments, finance, logistics, agency, media, human resources... So what does that mean? It means I need to get them to work for me, to get involved; they know that it's their job to work for the brand, to work for me; but they're not actually subordinate to me hierarchically. They have their own hierarchy. For

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example, the finance team has its own financial director. What you have to try and do is become a priority for the other departments. In that respect, as far as leading from that perspective is concerned, I think I learned a lot; I honestly think I'm quite good at it. If you explain your project, say why you want to take a particular type of decision, and succeed in getting the other person involved, who's going to refuse to work with you? I can sit down with the people I have direct contact with and talk, explain things, we each see the other's point of view, we pool our knowledge and put it in the service of a higher goal, to achieve our objective. I love that, it thrills me; I think it's rather similar to the experience I had at IESE – that everyone has something to say, that there are specialists in every field, and that you can always carry on building upwards.

Was there anything about the management structure you didn't like?

Since Procter is such a gigantic multinational, and there are so many top quality people working there who have always been taught to be proactive and enterprising, you often find there are conflicts which, although they might appear to be about business issues, are not actually about the business at all. Often there are other issues at stake, personal issues, professional jealousy, badges of achievement, status, power... You realise that these things really do influence the business and slow down decision making. There are a lot of conflicting interests. You're in a job where you have to cover, or attend to, your bosses' hidden agendas, without ever understanding the real reasons behind it all.

How long were you with Ariel?

About two and a half years. When I reached the post of senior assistant brand manager, who is the person who goes to the important meetings, Procter started to plan a reorganization at global level. Procter had an obligation towards its investors and shareholders to double its turnover every ten years. And they saw that at global level they were not going to reach that goal; it was quite an ambitious goal. The reorganization consisted of creating a Global Business Unit (GBU) and a Market Development Organization (MDO). The idea was to be global (GBU) – setting a general strategy for each brand– and local (MDO) at the same time –by adapting the general strategies to each market and trying to be as close as possible to end consumers. The perception within Procter was that the GBU made off with the most interesting part of the work –designing and producing the advertisements, which would be global for the whole of Europe, etc.– while the MDO was left with the dirty work, the mere execution. At that point I was asked if I'd like to go to the GBU. "You're the person who knows most about Ariel," they said. "You can help us get through this transitional period." Working in the GBU meant, among other things, going to Geneva. I didn't want to leave Spain at that time; my mother had died a year and a half earlier and I didn't feel I wanted to leave my family. I made that very clear from the start and they took it very well. They told me that, since it was a period of transition, the GBU would be located in Madrid for at least a year. I suddenly found myself on the fourth floor (I'd always worked on the third floor, with all my colleagues), alone, with nobody else doing the same sort of work, alongside people from other departments. I was responsible for the business in Spain and Portugal. I had my boss in Madrid, wondering where he was going to be sent next, while the rest of the bosses with any experience were in Brussels.

How many people did you have in your team?

Nobody. I was left on my own in Madrid. At that point they promoted me to brand manager. My boss in Spain left; I had no assistant and my new boss was in Brussels. I was nobody's boss and nobody's subordinate. We were all caught up in the whirlwind of a reorganization in which it wasn't even clear where the brand manager's responsibility ended. Because of the way the switch from GBU to MDO had been communicated, it got to the point where even some of my

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former colleagues, who were on the floor below, actually started to see me as their enemy, or not really me so much as the post I occupied, the position I was in.

Tell me about your motivation, your career. There were a lot of things in Procter you clearly liked. Was there any more or less latent conflict developing?

By nature, or because of my upbringing, or my family background, or for whatever reason, all my life there's a part of me that's been searching for something, though it might be hidden at times or not show very much. I like working with people, I like to see the impact on their lives and be surrounded by them; I like to collaborate, I like to help. I don't why it is but I *need* to give myself to others, and I enjoy doing it. Maybe my original idea of studying medicine came from the same urge, a philanthropic urge, a desire to do something useful. The MBA makes you think a lot, it makes you look at a case from all sides, and you extrapolate from it; what would *I* do in that situation? As a result, you start to study your own motives. I went so far as to write, "This MBA makes you examine yourself so hard that at the end of it I don't know if I'll come out knowing myself better or more confused than ever".

What I started to think while I was at Procter was that I wasn't sure I wanted to work to create needs that weren't *basic* needs – I found it deeply unmotivating. Was I really helping a woman when I told her she would be happier if she used one of our products? At bottom, the doubt boiled down to whether what I was doing would really make people happier. That doubt stayed with me throughout those years at Procter. I valued my work in the organization very highly, and the people, but the product I was selling did not satisfy me; I didn't identify with the idea behind it.

The fact is I was stuck there, in front of my computer, with pressure coming at me from all directions – the local markets demanding that I satisfy their requests, and me trying to get someone to explain to me what I was supposed to be doing, because not even the lines of command were clear. I'd seen the typical Procter profile, all the people they hired were very responsible. Being responsible is all very well, provided you don't overdo it. Sometimes, you take on a degree of responsibility at work that makes you push yourself to the limits where you start being irresponsible towards yourself, because you're not taking good care of yourself.

What were the limits and what were the consequences?

What sparked the crisis was the workload, all the things people were expecting of me. I don't mind if I'm asked to produce 800 reports at once, that's OK, but when people are constantly coming to you and asking for things all at once... I felt bad because I didn't feel I was up to the job, I thought I was letting people down. Naturally, I started to try to explain to everybody and tell them, "I can't do it, I'm not going to give you what you're asking for, there's nothing personal about it, it's just that I can't do it." I even went to Brussels to speak to my boss, to tell him I had two whole A4 sheets full of priorities for the next two weeks, two pages, that I just couldn't cope. It's only fair to say that this was not something that blew up overnight. I started to feel isolated in a job in which I had to take on more responsibility, where really nobody would tell me what I was supposed to do. I was on my own. The organization wasn't giving any signals, because it was going through an upheaval... I started to feel overwhelmed, perhaps because the responsibility was too much for me. I began to see myself as a failure, I thought I was no good for anything, that I was incapable of taking on the new job I'd been given, and that the organization had made a mistake in giving me so much responsibility. Now, looking back, I know that that is a typical response to a situation of stress, because you blame yourself and you're incapable of saying no. You think you have to accept everything, you have to say you can whatever you're asked to do, you have to shoulder the entire burden, until one day you fall to pieces. I'd spent four months in which I'd been in a different city almost every day: Monday in Paris, Wednesday in Brussels,

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and Thursday in Rome. I used to get up at five in the morning to take the plane and attend meetings in which I knew absolutely no one.

One reads about stress, one imagines what it's like, and one sees it happening, but not everybody has actually experienced it. Tell me, what are the symptoms?

Today I'm in a position to be able to look back and picture it, and explain how you can become a nervous wreck in six months. I started to notice the first symptoms when I used to get home and couldn't switch off mentally. I kept on thinking about what I had to do the next day. I was so tired I couldn't even be bothered to enjoy myself. Going out with friends became a chore. I needed to find a balance, work was taking over my life, I had to shake myself out of it. I was so exhausted I didn't feel like making the effort, but I had to force myself. Leisure stopped being fun; it became just another item on my agenda. I started to want to organize everything, have everything under control, so as to maintain a balance. But in fact I wasn't doing that. I was planning every last minute of my life, wiping out every trace of surprise and spontaneity.

Were you sleeping properly?

I was sleeping very badly. Many weekends I just lay there in bed all day from mental exhaustion. I didn't want to get up because I was overwhelmed by the tasks I had waiting for me. I thought, "I'm going to get up now and start thinking about the trips I've got on Monday, how I'm going to organize my documents..." You take refuge in sleep so as not to have to think, or in TV, anything that requires no mental effort, any TV program that you don't really want to watch but that helps you not to think.

Any sporting activities?

Nothing at all, you're too tired, you just don't feel like it. Everything takes up too much of your time. You can't get moving. You know it would do you good, but you put the idea out of your mind.

The general tenor of your thoughts is grey and negative – I can't do it, I don't know how to...

I'll never be able to do it, I can't, I'm not capable, I'm worthless as a manager. Your self- esteem hits rock-bottom.

You undermine yourself, don't you? You mistrust yourself, you're your own worst enemy.

Totally. You feel a coward, because you think you're incapable of dealing with it, and that you're just trying to justify yourself by saying you're tired. People would try to help me, they'd even say they loved me, but it just made me feel worse. I stayed in my world, feeling cut off and guilty.

Everything suggests you were suffering from depression. Do you think it's genetic or a consequence of the working atmosphere you were in?

I think it was bit of everything. I don't think I started to really understand what being responsible means until after I'd been through all of that. Sometimes you want to be totally responsible, you want to do everything and do it well, as best you can. But you've never taken a good look at yourself and told yourself, "I'm going to do it as best I can, but I'm not perfect. I must learn that I have my limitations, but that even with those limitations I still deserve a life." I've got to be capable of accepting myself as I am, trying to improve things, but knowing when to say this as far as I can go, no further.

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Are you able to laugh at yourself?

Now, yes. Back then, I looked at the world around me and said to myself, "They must be mad. They don't realise I'm worthless, how can they have trusted me for so long?"

How long were you stuck in the tunnel?

The tunnel lasted for about five to six months, until I had a serious crisis. Apart from the feelings and sensations I've just been describing, apart from the tiredness, there came a moment when my heart would start racing or I'd start vomiting whenever the phone rang or an e-mail arrived. I had fits of nervous coughing. I used to arrive home in tears, a bundle of nerves... I thought I was good for nothing. The crisis came to a head around Christmas time. Before Christmas I had been to see my boss in Brussels and I'd said to him, "I've got a thousand priorities. Please, help me." What he did was take one of my two sheets of priorities and tear it up. "Forget about it," he said. But I was already in free fall. I thought I'd be able to rest over Christmas. It wasn't a matter of physical tiredness, it was the mental tiredness, which is much more subtle.

I went back to work after Christmas and I already had three trips planned to different cities; my secretary was organizing everything for me. One day of January I came into my office at 8 a.m., sat down in front of the computer, and didn't stop weeping until 12. I couldn't help it, I couldn't stop. At half past one I got up from my desk and spoke to a young woman at Procter who'd had a nervous breakdown herself and told her what was happening to me. I felt eaten up with anxiety. I met with the CEO and said to him, "I've got to speak to you for a moment, I'm glad I bumped into you, it's just to tell you that I'm going, I can't carry on, I don't know what's wrong with me, I just can't go on." He said to me, "You go home, Lucía, don't you worry about anything. Take as much time as you need; phone in tomorrow if you feel like it and tell us how you are." I went to see a psychiatrist, a very good doctor. I went to him feeling I was a complete failure, not knowing what was wrong with me, thinking I'd never get over it.

And how *did* you get over it?

To be honest, I really don't know. I don't know how to explain what it is in my life that has changed to make me feel so unafraid. When you're having anxiety attacks, there comes a moment when the thoughts you're having make your body produce a whole series of chemicals or hormones which create the tiredness you feel, the nervous cough, the vomiting. The first thing the doctor did was prescribe some medicines to deal with the physical symptoms and try to relax my state of anxiety. Then came the more difficult part, the therapy. It consisted of going to see him once a week and talking. What was I hoping to achieve by it? Since I felt incapable of doing anything myself, I wanted the doctor to save me. He said to me, "No, you'll have to save yourself". At first I was even more disconcerted, but as you talk you start to realise that in fact what the doctor gives you is a facade, a wall, from which everything you say bounces back to you.

And once you get those thoughts out, they don't hurt any more, do they? It's like when you have wind, isn't it?

That's right. I can talk about it now, but at the time I just couldn't get my head straight. I had so many thoughts crowding into my head at once, all fighting with one another. Some of them told me, "I want some peace and quiet, I want to be happy". At the same time, I said to myself, "If I keep on telling myself I want to be happy, I'll just get even more upset". It was as if I were two different people at once, it was a horrible feeling. I didn't use to think there was such a thing as a split personality, but for a while I started to wonder if I wasn't a combination of Yin and Yang. One of the two me's would say, you'll never succeed, you're no good at anything, you're useless.

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And another part of me, which didn't say anything at all, just prayed: please, please, I need to relax, Lucía, stop worrying. It's exhausting because you're arguing with yourself, and I'd never experienced that before with such intensity.

It's as if you have a judge inside you.

No, it's not even a judge. It's that there are two people, each one opposed to the other. But one is a slave driver, a terrible enemy, in the sense that she tells you, "You can't do it", "You're going to make a mess of it", "You're guilty". It was like the negative part of myself. It's a court that always looks for the bad things and never considers the good things. If you haven't experienced it, it's almost impossible to understand.

One thing you might try to do in that situation is not to judge your thoughts, simply observe them. Merely observing can help to cure things, can't it?

Yes, but it's impossible when you're broken inside, because you have an exaggerated sense of guilt that overwhelms you. Quite unjustly, you're unfair to yourself. If I feel bad, if I'm sad, why should I try to wreck myself? Who is that other me that keeps flogging me? But, obviously, it's me who's doing it! It's really very difficult to explain; if it hasn't happened to you, you won't understand it. Now, in hindsight, I've tried to analyse how it is that a person can be capable of inflicting so much harm on himself.

Are you still as exaggeratedly responsible as you used to be? Are you still such a perfectionist? Or do you handle it differently now?

I'm different. Now I'm genuinely responsible. I accept my limitations, and I don't feel bad about them. Before, I didn't accept them. Before, I was a fool.

And do you think there was an element of pride in it, of arrogance or intolerance?

I think there was, I don't know whether from my upbringing, from a misconception of religion, or because of the way I am. Perhaps a bit of everything, a mistaken attempt to attain perfection. You don't attain perfection by being perfect, but by accepting your imperfections. Before, I wanted to be perfect; now, I just want to improve what I've got, and laugh at myself.

So what did you do? You stayed a few months in Madrid, didn't you? And then you started to see the light at the end of the tunnel.

I was off work for three months. I spent the whole of the first month crying. In the second month I started to get involved in a few of the kinds of activities that appealed to me. I started going to painting classes, I forced myself to go out for walks so as not to be thinking about myself all the time. During the third month, particularly towards the end, I realised I was at peace again. I can't really explain how it happened, but I suppose that horrible tendency to fight with myself was starting to disappear... I did a bit of sport, I was sleeping better, I stopped worrying. And I started to have dreams, very powerful, vivid dreams, very realistic. The doctor told me that when you're under a lot of stress, the first way the tension gets out is through the subconscious, through dreams. During the last month I felt much more relaxed. And I realised that for a long time, with all that insistence on being responsible, I had always been doing things, I'd always wanted to be doing things, but I'd never let myself be carried away by the emotion of enjoying what I was doing. I'd been rationalizing everything too much. Eventually there came a time when I felt better and I said to myself, "All right, so now what do I do? Shall I go back to Procter? Yes, I could go back, but do I want to? No. All right, so I'm not going back, because I don't want to." For me that was a victory, being able to say to myself, "Yes, I *can* go back, but I'm not going to because

I don't *want* to. I'm going to do what I want to do." That was something I'd never experienced before. I let myself be guided by the pleasure principle, and for once I ignored that tyrant, duty.

What did you do?

For several years I had been doing a little bit for an NGO. In fact, one summer I'd gone to stay with a foundation in Latin America for two weeks. I'd always thought I'd like to spend more time there. So I said to myself, "What better opportunity than this! I'll go, it's something I want to do, that's decided." I asked Procter for three months leave. They reacted very intelligently, and also very amiably. They wished me luck and hoped I enjoyed the experience.

How did your Latin American adventure go?

The time I spent in Central America was a period of discovery, a kind of "Know thyself – again". I'd always thought I more or less knew myself, particularly with regard to basic values and things like that. Going there meant bringing those values face to face with a much harsher reality that's very different from the world we live in here. It meant that my idea of what were the important things in life was put to the test. I came back delighted with the experience because I realised I'd been on the right track all along. It's a strange feeling, I'd always thought the most important things were friendship, love, companionship, tenderness, trying to get ahead without climbing over others. I had already experienced these ideas here, in Spain, but going to another part of the world where life is so different and realising that those same values could be extrapolated to any circumstances, that they can and should be put into practice everywhere – that made me feel much more secure, more confident, more serene.

Did the social, political, cultural and economic circumstances you encountered over there influence you in any way? Did they leave their mark on you? Did you say to yourself this is what I want to do, or was it a passing thing?

Apart from the thing about values, another thing that happened to me when I arrived there was that I discovered how you react to things you've always seen in a slightly idyllic light. What I mean is, when I was little I used to think, "Wouldn't it be wonderful to be a missionary, to have adventures and help other people" And when I grew older I thought, "Well, it wouldn't be bad to spend some time there, among the huts, working with people..." But the first thing I found when I arrived –I was watching a group of women who were inaugurating a bank, and then I had dinner with them– was that I was utterly disgusted by it, quite literally. I'm saying it now and I'm proud – not to have felt that way but to be capable of accepting that my first reaction to poverty, the first response it aroused in me, was, "This is disgusting! I'm getting out of here!" Maybe five months earlier, before my nervous breakdown, I'd have said, "That's a terrible thing to say! How can you be so callous?"

It would have made you feel guilty?

Yes. But now I can say, yes, I found it disgusting. So what? Aren't I allowed to be disgusted by it? What's wrong with finding it disgusting? Does that make me a bad person? No, quite simply that's the way I am. So when you really have to face up to situations like that and you see how you react, it helps you know yourself as you really are and find out whether this is the place for you or not. I was very keen to work in something that had a direct impact on other people. Being there helped me to see the reality of aid work, to understand that it's not a pretty reality, nor a perfect one, and that not everything works the way it should, that there's still a lot that needs improving. It showed me that the aid industry needs to become more professional. It also brought it home to me that I could never go and live in a country like that. I might go there for a

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couple of years, but that's a different matter; I couldn't live in those conditions on a permanent basis, I'm just not cut out for it.

You must have encountered an extraordinary human warmth and goodness.

I think I'm fairly realistic in that respect. They're neither better nor worse than us. They are people like you or me, with needs that are very different from ours. Like most people, you expect there to be a feeling of solidarity in the air as soon as you arrive; but what you find, at least at first, is that solidarity is not the feeling that comes across most strongly. Once I had come to terms with that initial coldness, I gradually came to feel closer to the people I was with. Today they are among the dearest friends I have. I was there for three months, then I came back and started to look for a flat. I came back feeling incredibly at peace with myself, taking each day as it came.

Did you go back to work at Procter?

Of course. As soon as I arrived I spoke to the director; I still had fifteen days leave left. I went to see him and he told me they had a job in mind for me, and he asked me how I felt about taking it. I said I'd be delighted; since I had come back feeling sure of myself, I knew I could do a good job at Procter. They offered me an interesting job managing all the brands of cleaning products such as Fairy, Don Limpio, Viacal, Swiffer and Febreeze, for Spain and Portugal, with a team of three people under me, reporting to the director. I set to work and I enjoyed it since it was a long time since I'd done that kind of thing.

Didn't you find it difficult coming back to the comfort of the West?

Not at all, because for me comfort is a good thing. The fact that the people over there don't have it –and I wish they did, and we must do our best to see that they get it– but that doesn't mean I should reject the comfort I already have, does it? I readapted to work, with a very interesting team. While I was there I received an offer from the foundation I had gone to Central America with.

What is it about the NGO that attracted you?

On the one hand, a job in which I could really have an impact on the Third World. That appealed to me. On the minus side, what can I say? Obviously, working for an NGO you're not going to have the same social prestige, nobody's going to see you as somebody important. You step outside the world of normal people with their career paths, their sponsors within the organization, and headhunters calling you every five minutes offering you sums I'd never imagined before. Then you get the typical pressure from your friends, and the society around you. What do you think you're doing? How can you bear to go off into that sort of parallel universe?

Even your nearest and dearest try to hold you back.

I didn't ask everyone for their opinion, there are only a few people's opinions that really count in my life, one of them being my father. He threw up his hands, a safe job, now his little girl's back at Procter, that's wonderful, a promising future, she's had reference letters saying how marvellous she is, and now she says she wants to go and join an NGO! He looked at me as if to say, "Are you planning to become a nun or what?" I said of course not. All the same, my father has always told us we should do whatever makes us happy.

What about the salary?

If I accept the job, I'll earn half what I've been getting up to now. On the one hand, I have a very strong personal motivation, knowing that I'll be working to help other people cover needs that may be very basic, not just food and clothing, but also things like self-respect, the value of your own effort, dignity, and so on. I don't know what to do.

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